



From Erving to Goffman

A Work in Performance?

Yves Winkin

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Goffman in the Open Series

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translated by

*Yves Winkin &
Wendy Leeds-Hurwitz*

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PROLOGUE

Regal Goffman, Against all Odds

A soft light from outside shines on his back, hair, and right cheek. He turns his head towards the lens that overlooks him with a serious air, without smiling. Around him, piles of notes, pencils in a holder, a notebook. Nothing is missing, not even the hand-cranked pencil sharpener behind him. Erving Goffman poses majestically in his office, late 1974 or early 1975.¹ No one had ever seen him like this, but it was to become his official image, and the one still most prominently displayed on the internet today. The photo was taken by Frederick A. Meyer, a press photographer who worked for the *Philadelphia Bulletin* for thirty-five years.² Meyer was commissioned by *The New York Times*, whose *Book Review* was to publish a review of Goffman's latest book, *Frame Analysis* (Rosenberg, 1975). How is it that Goffman, well-known for his refusal to be photographed, permitted it this time? Some have suggested that he was flattered by *The New York Times's* request. He was very fond of *Frame Analysis* and was undoubtedly prepared to make a promotional effort. But this was not the first time *The New York Times* had published a review of a Goffman book: *Relations in Public* had been so honored three years earlier (Berman, 1972). We might then suggest that he trusted Frederick A. Meyer, who lived, as Goffman did, in Philadelphia, was the same age, and had already photographed him a few years earlier.³

¹ See first photo in the insert.

² Email from René Salomon, January 26, 2019.

³ A photo of Goffman taken by Meyer appeared in *Time Magazine* on January 10, 1969 (p. 50); another appeared in *Time Magazine* on April 10, 1972 (p. 47). The mug that Goffman

But we can propose another explanation: Goffman was a performer. He was not the stand-up type—rather, a professional who performs, i.e., who brings his public persona to life with great seriousness and rigor.

Let us return to the photograph published in *The New York Times*. Its professionalism is obvious: the slightly bird's-eye view, probably taken from a stool, the side lighting, the capture of Goffman's gaze. But Goffman's professionalism matches the photographer's: He poses seated behind his desk, hands folded, in jacket, white shirt, and dark tie, very dignified, without a smile, but no sign of exasperation either. No one could guess his height—Goffman was about 1.60 m (5'2") tall. No one had ever seen him like this, surrounded by his files. But for all the seriousness he projects here, no one could deny the possibility that he might be wearing shorts and sandals under his desk. It was as if his readers were to understand: "I'm a researcher totally committed to my work; you can see it emerging all around me." In fact, among the manuscripts is perhaps that of a text to be published in 1976: "Picture Frames," the second chapter of *Gender Advertisements*,⁴ which reads:

When a renowned scientist graciously submits to a magazine interview (in the interests of disseminating knowledge), he is likely to be posed fingering his equipment as though a slice of his occupational life had been caught: he is shown peering into a microscope, writing a formula on the board, holding a test tube up to the light, or arranging a fossil. Thereby, he crudely mimes a posture plucked from his own role, momentarily transforming the living tools of his trade into dramaturgic equipment and himself into a pantomimist of fixed expressions. And what we see is not a photographic record of an actual scene from the scientist's life, as would be available were a secret camera trained on his laboratory, nor a clever contrivance of such a photographic record (this presented either as a real one or as an admitted simulation), but something that is *only* to be found as a posing for a picture, having been staged in response to a conception of what would make a colorful, telling photograph, and, behind this, a conception of what constitutes the appropriate convention for "representing" the particular calling. (Goffman, 1979, p. 19)

holds in both photos indicates that these were taken at the same time, as part of a set. It has often been said that Goffman was furious at being revealed in this way in *Time*. According to Dean MacCannell, Goffman only agreed to be photographed again on condition that certain details of his life were not mentioned (email to Yves Winkin [YW hereafter], December 29, 2021).

⁴ *Gender Advertisements* first appeared as a monograph in *Studies in the Anthropology of Visual Communication*, vol. 3, no. 2 (Fall 1976). It was then published as a book in 1979 by Harper and Row.

Goffman was certainly aware of all this when he posed amidst his papers for Frederick Meyer. Rather than the more typical academic attire of polo shirt and khaki pants, he is shown wearing a black-tie ensemble, and sitting at his desk with his hair neatly combed and his hands wisely folded.⁵ But he did not pretend to write, as many writers caught “in the act” do; he did not lean against a bookcase full of bound books, as many politicians so often do; and he did not put his glasses on his nose as if he were reading. Rather, he consciously became a “pantomime with frozen expressions.” Unlike most scholars, who might have naively put on an act in front of the photographer, Goffman knew exactly what he was doing, and to show it, he installed three details in the image that show he is not naive: no pen in hand, no books behind him, no glasses on his nose. In this way, he keeps some distance from his assumed persona, all while playing along for the magazine. It is this constant reflexivity that is fascinating about Goffman: He put his work into practice in his life. If his work, which was comprised of written texts, was about competence, his public life, which entailed accomplishments in the here and now, was about performance. I am not attempting to set up an opposition between his private life and his professional life; rather, I am drawing a distinction between his life in the public eye (including at a restaurant where he dined privately with friends) and his life “under the radar,” whether at home or when he was doing fieldwork incognito. My working hypothesis is that whenever he was to be found in public, Goffman was hyper-managing the impressions he was making, to allude to one of his most famous concepts.⁶ No doubt we are all looking to make a good impression, as Goffman suggests. That’s what the “presentation of self in everyday life” is all about. But in Goffman himself, as shown by his pose for Frederick Meyer’s camera and his analysis of scientists miming their own gestures for a professional photographer already quoted, there is an acute awareness of what is at stake in these “public relations.”⁷ One could argue that he deliberately chose how to represent himself.

To establish this hypothesis, I will begin by tracing his life, from his childhood in Manitoba to Philadelphia, where he settled comfortably in the late

⁵ Let’s not forget that he can be seen in shorts and sandals on the cover photo of the collective book *Le Parler frais d’Erving Goffman* (Editions de Minuit, 1989). The photo was taken surreptitiously by Isaac Joseph on a Philadelphia street in the late 1970s.

⁶ The notion of “impression management” appears at the very beginning of his first book (Goffman, 1959, pp. 1–16).

⁷ Relations in public form the core of several of his works (Goffman, 1971; Goffman, 1963).

1960s. I will then trail him as he gives lectures across the United States and around the world. It is in this eminently public situation that I will observe him performing in a highly constructed manner. Erving eventually became Goffman through his books, of course, but also through his performance work.

Strangely enough, little documentation of his performances has survived. Very few photographs, no film, no video, and no sound recordings. How did this man, famous since the early sixties, manage to escape capture? Admittedly, he had been known to interrupt his lectures to run after a photographer to whom he had not granted consent. Despite the fact that all performers asking not to be recorded still always seem to end up bootlegged, apparently this was not so for Goffman. Only one sound recording has surfaced, and this was eventually published (Goffman, 2012b). Otherwise, nothing. We have to rely on the notes of a few participants, on their memories, sometimes many years later. But it seems essential that we at least try to reconstitute this Goffman—the oral Goffman—and not limit ourselves to the extracts of written work he read in public. For Goffman was, as in front of the photographer, very conscious of what he did when delivering a presentation in public. The proof is in the text “The Lecture,” included in his last book, *Forms of Talk* (Goffman, 1981). How many sociologists have reflected on what happened to them behind a microphone, to the point of turning it into a text—or rather, a lecture which was read and later turned into a publication? Many of his peers have produced an oral work, yet none of them have produced a lecture about their lectures. This is what makes Goffman’s performance work unique. As a John Cage of the social sciences, he could easily have adopted the musician’s phrase in describing his own work: “My intention has been, often, to say what I had to say in a way that would exemplify it; that would, conceivably, permit the listener to experience what I had to say rather than just hear about it” (Cage, 1961/2011, p. 23). Thus, the life of Goffman is also an introduction to his work. His work, unlike that of many of his contemporaries, has turned out to be astonishingly ageless. What is the secret of its longevity?